met him in January 2009, seeking a better rate for sending out bulk SMSs for the general elections. ‘I was impressed with his strong “nationalist” desire to see the Congress being replaced by the BJP,’ recalls Goyal. The two met for dinner with like-minded friends a few days later and their discussions led to the setting up of an advocacy group, Friends of BJP, with Jain as the convenor.

In May 2011, Jain wrote a remarkably prescient blog which caught the attention of Modi. ‘The BJP’s approach needs to be to work towards creating a wave in 2014, across the country and especially in the 330–350 seats where the BJP is competitive. Switch focus from maximizing allies to maximizing seats for 2014 . . . the party must change its approach from winning 175 seats to winning 250 to 275 seats.’

For the 2014 elections, Jain created a digital software system that was truly revolutionary. It would create a voter identity database right down to the booth level. ‘We could track the smallest of households and use the data to build a volunteer base at the booth level which is critical in an election,’ a Team Modi member told me. If anyone wished to volunteer for the Modi campaign, all they needed to do was dial 7820078200 and punch in their voter ID card number. The NaMo volunteer programme was kick-started in September 2013 soon after Modi was declared the BJP’s prime ministerial candidate. ‘It was Rajesh who pushed for the “Power of One” voter registration and the NaMo volunteer programme first, and he did it all with his own money,’ says a BJP leader admiringly. Along with another IT professional, Bangalore-based B.G. Mahesh, Jain also created the India272.com portal, a site aimed at further widening the volunteer base for Modi’s campaign. He also set up the pro-Modi right-wing website Niticentral.com. The low-profile Jain didn’t want to speak on record, but a BJP leader described him as a ‘real rock star’.

The third key takeaway was the complete 360-degree approach to the election campaign. When journalists tracking the BJP’s manifesto arrived at the party headquarters in early April, they were given a pen drive with a film and the contents of the manifesto. The manifesto release was not just live on television, it was also playing out on the party websites, YouTube,